



I DID NOT TELL HALF OF WHAT I SAW, FOR I KNEW I WOULD NOT BE BELIEVED

MARCO POLO REACHES SHANGDU (c. 1275)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Rise of international trade

BEFORE

106 BCE The first caravan to travel the full length of the Silk Road carries Chinese ambassadors to Parthia.

751 CE Defeat of the Chinese army at the Talas River prevents Chinese expansion west along the Silk Road.

1206 Genghis Khan unites the Mongol tribes, beginning Mongol conquest of Central Asia and China.

AFTER

1340s The Black Death spreads along the Silk Road, reaching Europe in 1347.

1370–1405 Tamerlane makes extensive conquests, briefly reviving the Mongol empire and the Silk Road.

1453 The Ottoman conquest of Constantinople blocks Europeans' land route to Asia.

Venetian merchant Marco Polo's arrival at Shangdu, the capital of the Great Khan Kublai, in 1275 marked the end of a four-year journey. He had traveled from Italy to the Mongol capital Shangdu along the length of the Silk Road, an ancient network of routes that had been carrying precious goods between

Long-distance trade from China to the Middle East is **damaged** by the collapse of traditional powers.



Mongols conquer lands through which the Silk Road runs, **improving** the route's **security**.



Trade along the route increases, attracting European merchants including Marco Polo.



The **collapse of Mongol rule** and rise of the Ottoman Empire render the route's territory **less secure**.



European powers seek **alternative maritime trade routes** to the east.

China and Europe for centuries. The Silk Road had first become a conduit for trade when the Chinese Han Dynasty pushed into Central Asia in the late 2nd century BCE. From then on, goods such as jade and silk were carried west, passed from caravan to caravan by a series of merchants, to be met by caravans of furs, gold, and horses